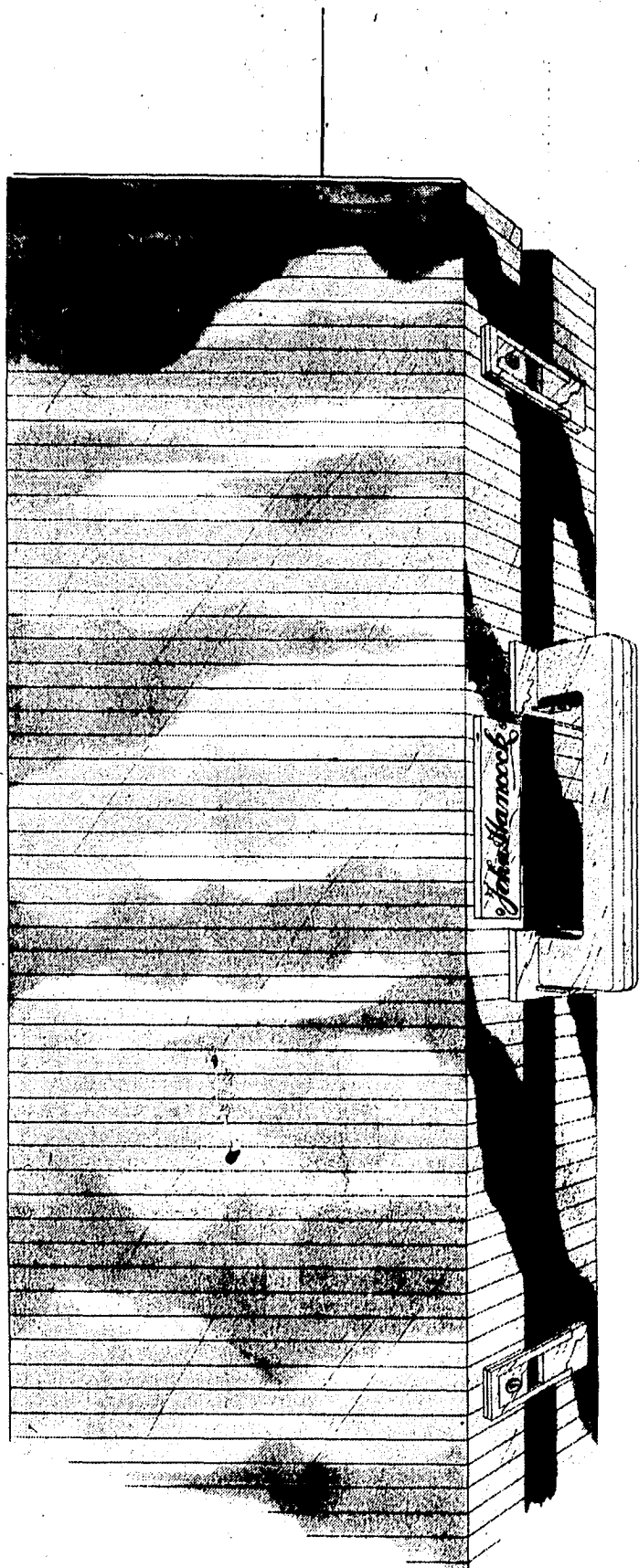
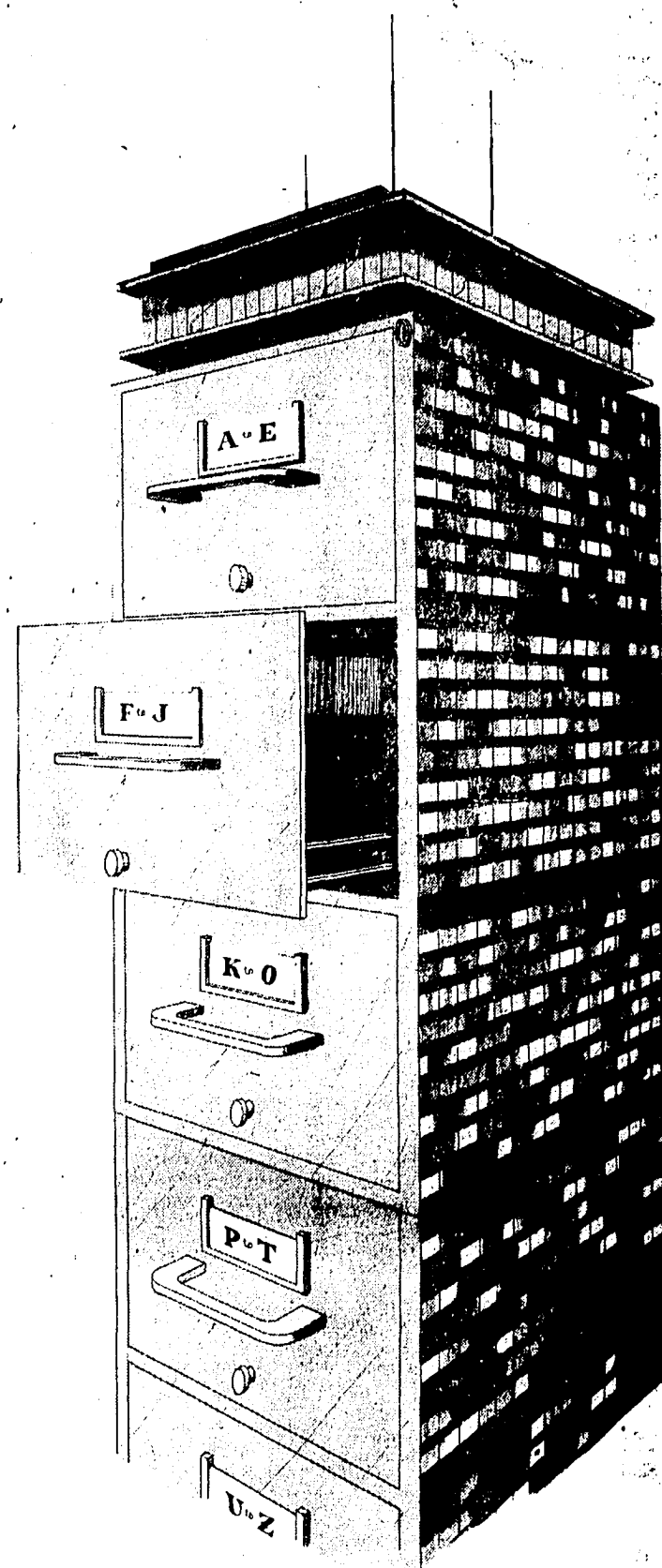




Boston's two tallest buildings

Originally scheduled to open in 1971, the John Hancock Building is now almost complete — topping the nearby Prudential tower by a little height and a lot of expense. How good, really, are these architectural giants, the most prominent features of Boston's skyline? The Globe asked its architecture critic to provide the following critique of Boston's two tallest buildings.



Illustrations by Vaughan McGrath

By Robert Campbell
 Special to The Globe

"The two tallest buildings in Boston are owned by rival insurance companies — the stockily provincial Prudential Building and the rakish, slender, very New York John Hancock Tower."

So writes Lonathan Raban, an English social critic, in a new book on cities.

"Stocky," "rakish" — the words provide a good capsule summary of the two buildings. And they show how the Pru and the Hancock are al-

ready one of those Ying-Yang pairs of opposites, like Classic and Romantic or Weber and Fields. You can't discuss one except in terms of the other.

These two Boston skyscrapers seem such opposites: the Hancock so chic, so Gucci, the Pru so ungainly, the Filene's basement of architecture. Yet at heart they're both big commercial towers dropped into a still predominantly low-rise city, and in that sense they are brothers under the skin.

It's in those skins that the contrast between them is vivid. Every joint

and surface of the Hancock is crafted with the loving, costly skill of a jeweler. By comparison, the Pru looks all botched and patched together out of materials bought from a Grossman's catalogue and assembled by a dropout from upholstery school.

Where the Hancock's green glass skin glitters, the Pru tower is swathed in a horrible, meshy, scaleless substance that looks like something you would pull down over your pawnshop to keep out thieves. The adjacent apartment slabs are covered with brick laid in peculiar panels with bent-out edges, giving the ap-

pearance of cardboard instead of masonry. The shopping plaza, windy and bare, is entered by a system of stairs and escalators so pompous that they cut it off from the city life around it. And all the Pru buildings are needlessly tall, with football fields of useless space between them.

Yet beyond the surface clumsiness, the Pru has hidden virtues. Compared to the Hancock, it at least invites your participation.

You can go to the top of the Pru for brunch. You can shop, sit, stroll. Where the Hancock is incredibly homogeneous, the Pru is a loosely mixed

grille of apartments, offices, parking, auditorium, hotel. For all the Pru's lack of charm, it creates action and has done a lot to revitalize its neighborhood — witness the successful, city-gaudy strip of commercial street life facing it across Boylston.

As art — as architectural form — the Pru has got to be one of the worst buildings of its kind, just as the Hancock is probably one of the best. Which one works better as part of the city — or if either works well at all — is harder to say.

The Hancock people are wary of the media. One can't blame them.

Cautiously, on the telephone, Harry Cobb, the partner in charge for the architects, I.M. Pei and Partners, reveals that he received a recent call from The Boston Globe — yes, The Globe — demanding that he confirm or deny a rumor that he has told the owner that the top 10 floors of the Hancock will have to be removed.

That call, Cobb is able to suggest — his voice seems to drift slightly — was a disheartening one.

After hearing that, one doesn't even want to write about the building. Fairness seems to call for every-

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one to shut up for awhile. Who would wish to add to the Job-like burdens of those who must see this building, still unfinished, through to completion and then suffer through what probably will be years of litigation?

But finished or not, the Hancock is by now firmly in the public domain, and enough of it is now built to suggest what kind of building it will be. It's time we looked at it for something beyond caved-in foundations, broken windows, sidewalk gales or stories about reinforcing the structural core.

Already clear is that the Hancock is going to be even more fascinating as a finished building than it has been during the years of construction fiascoes.

Everyone seems to be talking about it. But no one interestingly, seems to be quite sure what he thinks. Most people have mixed reactions.

And they're right.

The building is simultaneously wonderful in itself and highly questionable in relation to its physical and social surroundings.

Typical comments grasp this paradox. "It's a great building — for some other city," is a common reaction. "It's a magnificent monument to the best urban ideas of 1920," say others. "It's the greatest skyscraper — let's hope it's the last." And so on.

It's not surprising that we slip into such paradoxes in describing it, for the Hancock is the late-blooming progeny of the most famous paradox in modern architecture, Mies van der Rohe's classic, Wildean cliché: "Less is more."

But even Mies may not have envisioned a building whose lessness would extend to creating an entire exterior of 4-by-12 foot mirrors and nothing else but entrances and a discreet mechanical louvre near the top).

In a way, the Hancock is a refined New York cousin of all those corny Midwestern cars with their modishly concealed windshield wipers and hide-away headlights. The Hancock is hide-away everything.

It doesn't even have a visible top — the building appears to be simply sliced off at an arbitrary point. How different from the Pru, with its characteristically ill-fitting pagoda cap. The Hancock also lacks any kind of base or bottom. The lowest glass panes simply sit on the plaza, without so much as a sill. In both respects the Hancock is perhaps unique among prominent skyscrapers.

But top and bottom are only two of the words left unspoken by this building. It doesn't, for instance, say window or wall — the whole exterior is the same uniform, reflective surface. It doesn't say Boston — it could be anywhere. It tells you nothing about its own construction. It also tells you nothing about what different kinds of people, what different

activities may be occupying its various spaces.

You feel the full power of these silences only when you compare the Hancock with a building like Boston City Hall, a work which literally spills its guts on each of these counts and gains its architectural strength from doing so.

The Hancock renounces all that to concentrate on being, as expressively as possible, a very few things: tall, crisp, light, insubstantial.

The notion of tallness was basic to the client's vision for this building. Like adolescent boys comparing size, the Hancock and Pru were both out to win the height championship of Greater Boston. Given this absurd goal, the Hancock architect achieved it with enormous skill and elegance.

Especially on its two short sides, the building must be one of the strongest expressions of sheer tallness since Gothic times. A vertical notch running the building's full height slices these already thin sides into glittering blades. The building seems incredibly thin, incredibly tall, a mirror balanced on edge rather than a solid mass.

It's this planar quality, along with the cut-diamond effect of the two sharp corners, that immediately lifts the building out of the class of all those other banal glass-box designs. And the recessive, watery green color, reflecting sky and clouds, makes the building seem to fade into the sky as if it went on up forever. The lack of any lid, any change at the top, intensifies this; so does the lack of a bottom. The whole 60-story mirror drops like a seamless curtain from the sky to the sidewalk.

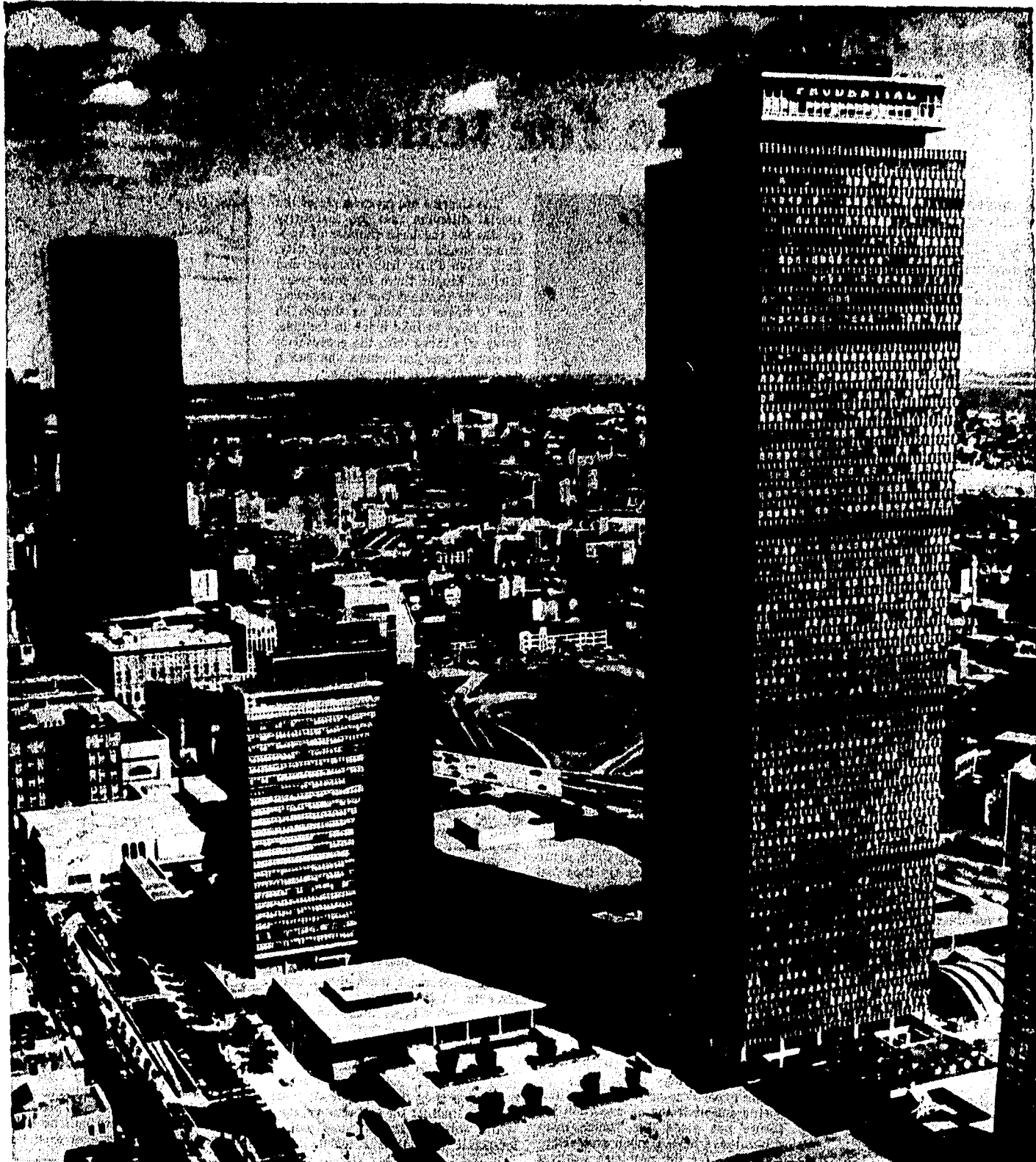
It's a giant crystal from Krypton dropped into our cluttered little brick city, outlandish and beautiful but perhaps tending to trivialize everything around it.

As you walk around the Hancock, though, there are great pleasures. Trinity Church is reflected in it; so, you suddenly notice, are you.

By holding up a mirror to the city, the Hancock turns the street life around it into theater. Afternoon sun off the west wall mottles Copley Plaza with a trellis of light. On the side streets, the Hancock spreads out its lower floors to the sidewalk, effectively doing its job of shaping the street space.

It's at the main entrance that you first notice something going seriously wrong. The entrance — where building really meets city — is the crux of this building's problem.

Just as a purely artistic issue, the question of how on earth to penetrate a 60-story mirror is terribly difficult. Any opening in a form this huge and uniform is a violation. Obviously, the architect saw the problem and attacked it head on, with an entry system of bubble-dome canopies that are additions to the building rather than holes in it. But the device is a mixed success at best.



The Prudential tower and the John Hancock Building.

(Globe aerial photo by Ed Fitzgerald, shot from the Back Bay looking toward downtown)

A more bizarre solution to the entrance problem is proposed by one local architect. The Hancock company, he suggests, should go to East Boston, buy a three-decker, saw off the front ten feet — all three stories, including the stoop — and glue the whole thing onto the front of the Hancock Tower.

Of course it's a joke, but it dramatizes like nothing else the amazing remoteness, scalelessness, coldness, lifelessness of this building, built for the inhabitants of another planet rather than people who dwell in three-deckers.

Another architect suggests that

what the Hancock really needs is lace curtains.

The urge among architects to make such graffiti-like suggestions is as strong as a child's urge to make tracks in new snow. The Hancock, so beautiful, is too virginal. It screams for a human imprint.

The Pru makes an illuminating contrast. No one would even dream of discussing it as an esthetic object.

It certainly shares much of the Hancock's blank, rejecting character. Yet for all its clumsiness, it does have a city-like mixture of uses and people, shops and a skating rink. In this sense it makes a stiff gesture of outreach to what is around it. Even at

the worst, it's at least too ugly to be self-obsessed.

Where, in the Hancock, is even this much of the city's complexity, its overlaying of one activity on another? What life it has it gains by reflection. Will walking past any side of this iceberg ever be really interesting?

Architects today are going through a transition that was possibly described best in Yeats's poem, "The Circus Animals' Desertion," in which the poet describes how in middle life he abandoned what he calls "dreams" — images "that grew in pure mind" — and chose instead to write about: "Old kettles, old bottles, and a broken can,

"Old iron, old bones, old rags, that rav-
ling slut
Who keeps the till ...
I must lie down where all the ladders
start
In the foul rag-and-bone shop of the
heart."

Maybe the Hancock too grew too much "in pure mind." The John Hancock Co., after all, is in the insurance business, and somewhere behind all that dreamy reflecting glass there is a raving slut who keeps the till.

Rags and bones, stoops and lace curtains — too much of the interesting mess of life seems edited out of this beautiful, glacial building.